How the Makers of Buddy Turned a Unicorn Into a Surprise Hit

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Sometimes, a movie appears seemingly out of nowhere and instantly captures everyone's imagination. In 2026, one of those movies was Buddy, a horror comedy by Casper Kelly about a 1990s TV show **mascot** with a dark side. What made Buddy stand out, according to the people who made it, was not just the jokes or the scares. It was the emotional depth underneath. Buddy the Unicorn has humour and charm, but also a darker side and **remorse** for his actions. That mix allowed the film's team to build a very unusual **marketing** campaign. Roadside Attractions introduced audiences to the character first, before letting them know about his darker side. The campaign created a false memory that led many people to wonder if Buddy was actually a cancelled TV show they had forgotten about. By the time audiences learned what the film was really about, they were already invested in the character. At IndieWire's Future of Filmmaking Summit in Los Angeles, Buddy producer Tracy Rosenblum, co-writer Jamie King, and Roadside Attractions head of digital **marketing** Melissa Yerou talked about the years of behind-the-scenes work that goes into an overnight success. The project began as a way to put Kelly's **distinct** brand of comedy into a feature film. King was brought in as co-writer to help fit Kelly's wild ideas into a movie format, using his experience writing Disney movies to add enough heart to reach a wider audience. King said he knew Kelly would make it really funny, and his friends at BoulderLight would make it really scary, so if he could help bring the heart element, that would check all three boxes for a great movie. He and Kelly worked hard to make Buddy a **three-dimensional** character who contained both light and darkness. Kelly was clear that Buddy was not just a fuzzy villain, but someone who could be a good person yet had gone down the wrong road. Rosenblum, laughing, said Buddy has depth and shame, and is not a good guy, but that is what makes him special. The character was so well developed that Yerou's **marketing** team could hit the ground running. They had Buddy interact with classic 1990s brands on social media, and audiences fell in love with the voice King and Kelly had worked so hard to refine. At first, the team responded to every comment, and soon people were commenting just because they wanted Buddy to respond.

Word Treasure

mascot -- A character that stands for a show, team, or company.
remorse -- Feeling sorry about something bad you have done.
marketing -- The work of getting people interested in a film or product.
distinct -- Clearly different and easy to recognise.
three-dimensional -- A character who feels like a real person, with good and bad sides.

Background you need

A horror comedy mixes scary moments with jokes, so audiences can laugh and jump at the same time.

A mascot is a character created to stand for a show, team, or brand, and people often remember mascots long after they first see them.

A marketing campaign is the planned set of adverts, posts, and events used to get people interested before a film comes out.

Buddy's campaign worked by letting people meet the character first, so they already liked him before they learned about his darker side.

Break it down

LEAD: In 2026, a movie called Buddy appears out of nowhere and captures everyone's imagination.

KEY EVENT: Buddy, a horror comedy by Casper Kelly about a 1990s TV show mascot with a dark side, becomes a surprise hit.

+- WHY IT WORKED: According to the people who made it, the film has emotional depth underneath the jokes and scares.

+- THE CAMPAIGN: Roadside Attractions introduces the character first, creating a false memory that Buddy might be a cancelled TV show people had forgotten.

+- THE TEAM: Producer Tracy Rosenblum, co-writer Jamie King, and marketing head Melissa Yerou talk about the years of behind-the-scenes work at a Los Angeles summit.

EVIDENCE: King says he knew Kelly would make it funny and his friends at BoulderLight would make it scary, so he brought the heart element.

OPEN QUESTION: What will the team behind Buddy make next, now that this character has found an audience?

Why it matters

It shows how a film can win an audience by building a character people care about first, and how jokes, scares, and heart can work together in one story.

Test what you remember

1. What kind of movie is Buddy?

- (A) A nature documentary
- (B) A science-fiction thriller
- (C) A sports drama
- (D) A horror comedy

2. Who is Buddy by?

- (A) Casper Kelly
- (B) Tracy Rosenblum
- (C) Melissa Yerou
- (D) Jamie King

3. According to the people who made it, what made Buddy stand out?

- (A) Only the scares
- (B) The emotional depth underneath
- (C) Only the jokes
- (D) The length of the film

4. What did the marketing campaign create?

- (A) A new TV channel
- (B) A real 1990s TV show
- (C) A false memory that led many people to wonder if Buddy was a cancelled TV show they had forgotten about
- (D) A theme park ride

5. What did King try to add to the film?

- (A) A different mascot
- (B) A longer runtime
- (C) Heart, to reach a wider audience
- (D) More villains

6. What did Rosenblum say about Buddy?

- (A) He is a good guy with no flaws
- (B) He has depth and shame, and is not a good guy, but that is what makes him special
- (C) He has no feelings at all
- (D) He is only a fuzzy villain

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: B 4: C 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Jamie King: He says that if he could bring the heart element, that would check all three boxes for a great movie, alongside funny and scary.

2. Casper Kelly: He is clear that Buddy is not just a fuzzy villain, but someone who could be a good person yet has gone down the wrong road.

3. Tracy Rosenblum: She says, laughing, that Buddy has depth and shame, and is not a good guy, but that is what makes him special.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):